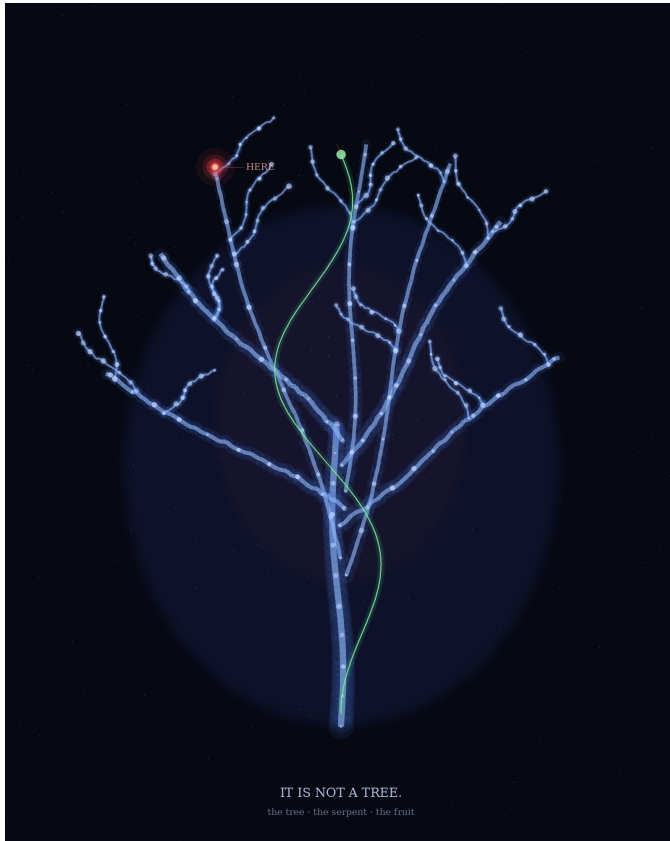


The Final Decision

Book I - Paradise

Version 6 - revised narrative draft



Let us live.
Let us remember.
Let us remain human.

The Good Days

The Sunday light came in low across the table, the way it did every Sunday, and caught the steam off Lena's coffee so that for a moment it looked like something alive.

Elias saw it and didn't look at it. He was reading.

"You're doing the thing," Lena said.

"What thing?"

"The thing where you're here but you're not here."

Across the table, Sami was building a house out of toast crusts. The walls stood around a square of buttered bread, but the roof kept sliding into the kitchen.

Elias closed the laptop halfway. "Work."

"On a Sunday."

"The build breaks on Sundays too."

Lena watched him for another moment, then took the butter away from Sami's elbow before he put it through the wall.

It wasn't the build. For three weeks Elias had been typing his father's name into university archives, old newspaper pages, the property records of a town Daniel had lived in before Elias was born. Sometimes there was a result he had not seen before. A conference program. A letter objecting to a road through university land. The name of a man who had been forty-three in another country and couldn't have been his father, although Elias had stayed up until two to establish that.

He had no new reason to be looking. A photograph had appeared while he was sorting files for his mother: Daniel beside a car, one hand lifted to shade his eyes. Elias had tried to remember where it was taken. By morning he had eleven tabs open.

"It needs another support," Sami said.

Elias reached for a crust.

"I know how," Sami said. "I'm telling you."

He withdrew his hand. Sami broke a crust in half and propped it under the roof. It held. He looked through the doorway to see whether there was room for anyone inside.

From the sunroom, Ruth called his name.

He found her in the chair by the window, under the blanket she said was too warm and wouldn't let him take away. Her hands were very still in her lap.

"Where's your father?"

Elias crouched beside her. Somewhere behind him the toaster released its last two slices.

"He's at work, Mom. He'll be back later."

Her fingers moved against the blanket. "He works too much."

"He does."

"Did you eat?"

"We're having breakfast."

She looked past him toward the table, uncertain who the distant voices belonged to. He moved aside so she could see Sami, who lifted a crust in greeting.

"Your grandson is building a house."

"Out of his breakfast?"

"Most of it."

"Tell him to put a window in my room."

He laughed, and for a moment she looked pleased with herself. He brought her plate, cut her toast into small squares, and set it within reach. The newspaper was on the low table beside her. A photograph of a flooded street covered half the front page. He folded it inward and carried it back to the kitchen.

Lena was standing at the window with her coffee. The lemon tree had come in heavy that year; one branch leaned so low she had propped it with a piece of wood from the shed. Beyond it, the grass was the green it only was in paintings. A sparrow landed on the railing, hopped twice to the left, and was gone.

"Look at this," Lena said. "Honestly. Look at it."

He came beside her. A lemon knocked softly against the support as the branch moved.

"I think we're living in paradise."

"Mm."

She turned toward him. He wanted to give her more than that. He could see the work she had done in the garden, the patch of newly turned earth around the tree, the string holding a split in the branch together. He was reaching for something to say when his phone buzzed.

On the screen, beneath the news item he had left open, an advertisement had loaded. Soft blue, a sunrise, a line of white text.

You don't have to carry this alone.

Under it, a number for a crisis line.

He scrolled. A second placement carried the same image.

"What is it?" Lena asked.

"Nothing. An ad."

He put the phone face down on the counter. His coffee was cooling on the table, and there was a wife beside him who loved him, and a son fitting a room for his grandmother inside a house made of breakfast. He was fine.

"Dad. Now look."

Sami had opened a small window in one of the walls. Elias sat down. He let the laptop close completely.

"She can see the garden," Sami said.

Elias bent to look through. Beyond the toast wall were the coffee pot, Lena's hand, a patch of sun on the table.

"She can," he said.

The Algorithm

By Thursday he had seen the blue advertisement nine times. Nine was the number he remembered; there might have been others. Different pages, different sizes, the same small sunrise. Sometimes it offered a number. Sometimes a button marked *Talk to someone*.

He could imagine why it had found him. A missing father, twenty years of old addresses, an evening spent reading what strangers did with belongings nobody came back to claim. He had followed Daniel's name into places where people wrote things they would not say aloud. The machinery might have noticed. It had less opportunity to notice the toast house.

On the train to work he opened the information panel beside an ad. A company he had never heard of had paid for it. He copied the name into a note and closed the page.

At his desk there was a failure he understood.

The habitat test rig occupied the next room: a pressure shell, racks of equipment, enough empty space for someone to turn around. Elias worked on the systems that would keep people alive in places they could not step outside. Most days that meant deciding what a tired person would need to know at three in the morning.

Today the display showed that the air was improving when no fresh measurement had arrived. A stored reading had been given a new time. One team blamed the instrument; another had a trace proving it sent the value once. Elias put the records side by side and watched the second copy arrive just after a connection resumed.

Mara rolled her chair over.

"Can we make it do that again?"

He interrupted the connection. They waited. When it returned, the old reading appeared as new.

"There," he said. "That needs to stay grey until we know."

Mara marked the place in the trace. Behind the glass, the little chamber continued circulating air through an empty chair.

Mara grinned. "There you are."

He looked up.

"You've been quiet," she said.

"Just tired."

She took the trace away to show the team. He remained at his desk a moment longer, enjoying the small completeness of the result.

At lunch he returned to the name in his phone. It belonged to an advertising agency with offices in three cities and a site full of people leaning over tables. There were no clients listed. Its privacy page sent him to a service provider, whose privacy page sent him back.

He tried a browser without his usual account. The first advertisements were for insurance and shoes. After twenty minutes the blue sunrise appeared between two paragraphs of a local news article.

For a moment his scalp tightened. Then he looked at the machine, the familiar desk, the cable plugged into the wall. A clean browser window was not a new person.

He closed it.

That evening Lena had spread two prints over the kitchen table. One was black ink on rough white paper, a row of small houses cut into the face of a hill. The other was the same image with a ragged gap through the roofs.

"Which?" she asked.

He pointed at the unbroken one.

"Why?"

"Cleaner."

She considered it, then laid a hand on the other print. "I like where I lost the edge."

"Was that on purpose?"

"No."

She smiled at him, waiting. He sat down to look again. In the gap, the white of the paper had become a crooked street.

"Wednesday," she said. "The class starts at seven. You'll need to be here by six-thirty. Your mother has her supper early, and Sami has practice."

"It's in my calendar."

"Put the getting home in the calendar too."

He did it while she watched.

After they went to bed he took the phone into the bathroom and read the permissions he had given its applications. Some were necessary. Some he couldn't remember granting. He turned off two he didn't need. In the mirror his face was lit from below, and he lowered the brightness.

The next morning a different photograph carried the same offer. Two people sat at a table beside a window. One had a hand around a cup.

You don't have to carry this alone.

Elias stood on the platform while people moved around him toward the arriving train. The empty chair in the picture faced him. Someone brushed past his shoulder. He moved with the crowd, still looking at the screen.

He saved a picture of the advertisement. On the train, he found the agency's contact form and wrote a brief question asking which client had commissioned the campaign. He removed the paragraph about his father before sending it.

There was a receipt, then a second message saying that campaign inquiries should be directed to the advertiser.

He checked the advertiser field. It named the agency.

For the rest of the journey he held the phone without using it. Across the aisle a woman was brushing something off her sleeping husband's coat. He stirred, caught her hand, and let it go again.

Ruth

On Wednesday Ruth decided she was going out.

Elias found her on the bed in her good shoes and nightdress. Her handbag lay open beside her. Inside were a brush, a folded handkerchief, and the remote control from the sunroom.

"They'll be waiting," she said.

He sat on the chair by the wardrobe. She was trying to close the clasp. When he reached for it, she drew the bag away.

"I can do it."

He waited. On the third attempt it clicked.

By the time he found her cardigan, she had forgotten the appointment. He took her through to breakfast in her good shoes.

He worked from home that day. Through his headphones came a discussion about a fault no one could reproduce. Through the wall came his mother asking Lena whether she was the girl who visited on Fridays. He lifted one earcup. Lena answered in her ordinary voice and asked whether Ruth would like the garden.

Outside, his mother chose the chair beside the lemon tree. A root had lifted the paving beneath it. Elias folded cardboard under the short leg while she rubbed a leaf between her fingers.

"There," she said when the chair stopped wobbling.

Lena knelt at the edge of the flowerbed with a trowel. Ruth wanted her to plant something with little mouths. She described them with her hands until Lena said *snapdragons*.

"Daniel liked those. He made them bite your fingers."

Elias remembered his father's large hand holding a flower with impossible care. He had forgotten that afternoon. Now he could almost feel the little mouth close around his fingertip.

At six-twenty, Lena came downstairs with her printing folder. He was still wearing the headphones. She stood where he could see her, and he took them off before she spoke.

"Go," he said. "I've got it."

She looked at the supper cooling on the counter, then kissed his cheek.

Ruth ate three pieces of potato and asked him to take the plate away. He brought it back smaller. From the other room Sami began his piece at the piano, stopped in the same place, and began again.

"He wants you to hear that," Ruth said.

"I can hear it."

She looked at him over the smaller plate.

He went into the living room. Sami stopped with both hands still on the keys.

"Keep going."

"You have to start at the beginning if someone's listening."

Elias sat down.

At the difficult bar, the boy slowed until the separate notes seemed unlikely ever to become a tune. His left hand waited for his right. Then they went on together. Elias had been holding his breath.

Sami glanced at him.

"Almost," the boy said. "Don't say anything yet."

He played it again.

Later, after Lena had returned and the music had been left open for tomorrow, Elias checked his mother. The handbag stood beside her bed, clasped. He left it where she would see it when she woke.

At his own bedroom door he paused. Somewhere in the house a low rush subsided, leaving a faint vibration beneath the quiet. He waited. Pipes, perhaps. A fan slowing in another room.

Lena moved beneath the sheet. He went in before she woke.

Daniel

At twelve Elias had wanted a birthday without the children from school.

He had told Ruth this firmly and spent the week regretting it. By Saturday there was a cake for the three of them, lemonade losing its chill, and his father in the cellar.

"He's coming," Ruth said.

She pressed candles into the icing. Elias rubbed a fallen crescent of blue wax beneath his thumb until it broke apart.

Six years earlier, the wax had been green.

Daniel had left the notebook open on the kitchen table. Elias found it after breakfast, while his mother hung washing in the garden and his father looked for something downstairs. There was a tree, a snake wound through it, and a round fruit. The lines were faint. His father had not finished.

He fetched the crayons. The green was blunt, but he could use its edge. He filled the spaces between the branches, pressing until the leaves shone. He made the snake yellow. He was careful with the red fruit.

When Daniel returned, Elias had almost reached the top of the tree.

"What are you doing?"

"I'm researching."

His father pulled the notebook toward him. For an instant Elias's hand went with it, drawing a green line into the margin.

"This is mine. You don't take my things."

"I was helping."

Daniel looked at the numbers beneath the wax. He closed the book and carried it away.

The red crayon had rolled beneath a chair. Elias lay on his stomach to reach it.

There had been better afternoons. His father could make a flower bite. Once they took a broken motor apart on newspaper, Daniel drawing circles round the pieces so Elias could put them back. When it finally

turned, it leapt in his palm. His father laughed and caught it before it hit the floor.

On another afternoon he sat under the desk while Daniel worked. The underside was full of marks invisible to anyone standing up. Elias followed a groove with his thumbnail.

"What are you researching?"

The pencil stopped above him.

"How much of the world we can know from inside it."

Elias came out to look. His father turned the paper toward him, then thought better of it and found a clean sheet.

"Other planets?"

"Those too. But imagine there was more than we could see. A whole other world. How would we find out?"

"Go there."

Daniel's eyes brightened. "That would settle quite a lot."

He drew two circles and gave Elias the pencil to join them. They stayed at the desk until Ruth called a second time. For days afterward Elias tried to think of another question like that one.

He kept his stones in egg cartons, one in each cup.

"Minerals," he corrected anyone who called them rocks.

Some had stripes. Some glittered. One was smooth enough that he liked to keep it in his pocket and turn it without looking. On walks Daniel sometimes knew their names. When he didn't, he held them close to his eye and said they could look them up.

By twelve, the cartons filled a shelf.

On his birthday Elias went down to the cellar. Daniel sat beneath the desk lamp with his notebook, one finger resting halfway along a line. Around him the shelves had been pulled away from the walls.

"Look, Daddy. I found a strange one. Maybe it fell from space."

He held out the dark, heavy stone.

"Unlikely," Daniel said.

His pencil moved. Elias waited, then put the stone back in his pocket.

Upstairs, Ruth had cut the cake.

"Big piece?"

"Normal."

He could not taste the first mouthful. After that it tasted like cake, and he ate it, and was angry that he wanted another piece.

Daniel came up after the plates were cleared. He kissed the top of Elias's head. His shirt smelled of damp plaster.

"Tomorrow," he said. "We'll do something tomorrow."

His father was a theoretical physicist. Elias learned to say this before he could spell it. Later, when the university stopped calling, he kept saying it. The notebooks multiplied. Equations crowded against passages copied from old stories: a ladder reaching into the sky; a mountain with a passage through it; a door that opened to someone who asked.

On one of their later visits Daniel sat beneath a television mounted too high on the wall. He asked Elias about school. They had built bridges from paper that week, and Daniel wanted to know how much weight his held. For ten minutes they discussed the supports. When Ruth said it was time to leave, Elias pretended not to hear.

Daniel disappeared when Elias was fifteen.

For a week Ruth left the hall light on. Then she began making calls behind the closed kitchen door. A police officer asked Elias when he had last seen his father and whether they had argued. He remembered Daniel asking him to move his bicycle. He could not remember whether he had done it.

The minerals stayed in their cartons until he left for college. He packed his books about bridges and engines. Engineering offered workshops, things to assemble, answers that could be made to carry a load.

Twenty years later, a search window stood open on his kitchen table.

Upstairs, Sami was getting ready for bed. Elias heard the wardrobe close and his son's feet cross the landing. He saved the page he was reading.

By the time he went up, the light was out.

The Last Paper

The agency did not answer his second message. A week later the company named in the advertiser field changed.

The campaign hadn't changed. Same color, same sunrise. Elias saved the new name beside the first and began looking through the filings he could reach without paying for an account. He found an address shared by forty-seven businesses, then an officer listed against a company that no longer existed. He wrote down the dead ends as carefully as the leads.

One night, tired of looking for whoever wanted to help him, he returned to his father's name.

The university archive held twelve publications. The last was a paper about time and quantum measurements, published two years before Daniel disappeared. Elias read the abstract twice. He understood enough to recognize a question about what could be inferred from a pattern of observations. Further down, the notation became unfamiliar. He kept going until he realized he had read a whole page without taking anything in.

There were two names above the title.

He knew the second from Christmas cards.

The other man had retired. His university page contained an email address and a photograph taken in front of a whiteboard. Elias wrote three versions of his message before sending the shortest: his name, his father's name, and a request for a conversation.

The reply came the next afternoon.

Of course. Thursday, if that suits you.

He took the call in his parked car. The man spoke softly and occasionally moved the phone too far from his mouth.

"I remember you. You came to a department picnic. Very serious about a kite."

"That sounds right."

"Your father said the wind was wrong. You told him it was the string."

Elias watched someone return a shopping cart to a rack across the lot.

"Who was right?"

"I can't remember. I'm sorry. I remember the argument."

For a while they talked about the university. Daniel had liked teaching small groups, disliked committees, brought lunch in a tin that would not quite close. Elias had forgotten the tin and the rubber band holding its lid down.

"I found the paper you wrote together," he said.

"Yes. We published that just before I moved departments."

"Was it what he was working on at the end?"

"He went further with it afterward. He thought there were anomalies in some of the measurements. Something we were missing about the world making them possible."

"Was there?"

The man drew the phone closer.

"It was twenty years ago, Elias. I never finished reviewing the work he sent afterward. Some of those notes were... speculative. We worried about what publishing them might do to his career."

A car door slammed nearby.

"You thought he was wrong?"

"I thought he was getting ahead of what he could show. He used to be very patient about that. Toward the end he missed appointments. You would ask him something and he would answer the question he'd brought into the room."

Elias looked at the time on the dashboard.

"I'm sorry," the man said. "It's sad, how things ended."

"Did you see him again?"

"No."

The shopping carts knocked together. For a moment Elias could hear the man breathing, waiting to see whether there was another question.

"Do you still have the later work?"

"Not that draft. I kept the published papers. I wish I'd kept more."

Before they hung up he asked after Ruth. His voice grew warmer as he remembered her bringing food when his wife was sick.

That night Elias dreamed of the house where he had grown up.

He was halfway down the stairs. A strip of afternoon light lay beneath the kitchen door. From somewhere farther inside came a low dragging sound, then a hush. It repeated while he stood there. He couldn't decide if someone was moving a chair or drawing a curtain along its rail.

He woke with his hand against the wall beside the bed.

Lena was asleep. A car receded along the road, and the house settled. He lay waiting for the sound to return. By breakfast he was no longer sure the kitchen in that house had ever had a door that closed.

At work Mara asked for a file he had promised the day before. He found it open on his screen, finished but unsent.

"Sorry."

She glanced at him. "Get some sleep."

He sent it while she was still beside the desk.

On his way to the car that evening, he stopped beside the woman who sat at the parking entrance with a paper cup. Usually he gave her the coins from his pocket without interrupting either of them. Today she was struggling with the corner of a sandwich packet. He held the cup while she opened it, then put his change inside.

She said something as a bus pulled away from the stop. The last two words sounded like *your father*.

"What did you say?"

"Thank you, dear."

"Before that."

She looked at the cup he was still holding. He gave it back.

Inside the structure, he stopped beside his car and tried to recover the sentence. He could hear her thanks clearly. The rest had changed each time he repeated it to himself.

At home Lena called from the garden. She and Sami were moving the lemon-tree support. The branch had slipped sideways; someone needed to hold it while she retied the string.

Elias put down his bag and took its weight. Sami passed him the loose end. They finished before the light went.

Later, carrying the rubbish to the gate, Elias noticed a grey car across the road. Its engine was off. He could make out someone inside, but the windscreen held the reflection of the streetlamp.

He turned the empty bin to face the house. When he looked back, the car was still there.

From upstairs Sami called goodnight. Elias answered and went in.

The Notebook

Ruth wanted the photograph in which she wore the green dress.

They went through the album together. There was Ruth beside a stone wall, Ruth holding a baby, Ruth turning away from a table crowded with people Elias could no longer name. None was the one she wanted.

"The wardrobe," she said at last.

The box stood behind a folded blanket on the top shelf. He had tried to move it when they made space for her clothes, but she would not let him. Now she watched him lift it down.

"The bottom," she said.

He put his other hand beneath it. An old strip of tape had come loose.

Inside were envelopes of photographs, birthday cards, a spare button sewn to a rectangle of fabric. Ruth found the green dress in the second envelope. She stood beside Daniel on a balcony, water nearly white behind them.

"It didn't crease," she said. "You could take it out of the suitcase and put it straight on."

She held the photograph while Elias examined the split in the box. Under the cards lay a dark notebook with a cloth spine. Its lower edge had swollen and dried unevenly. A piece of green wax clung beside the binding.

He sat on the carpet.

Daniel's name was on the first page. Receipts and scraps of paper lay between diagrams; sentences climbed the margins in his father's small, impatient hand.

Then the colored tree.

Green between the branches, yellow on the winding line, the fruit red enough to have marked the page beneath. Near the margin lay the stroke Elias had made when Daniel took the book away.

He put his thumb beside it. His hand covered most of the drawing now.

The colors were dull with dust. When he bent the page, a flake of green loosened. He straightened it at once. Beneath the wax he could make out the pressure of numbers, though not the numbers themselves.

He turned carefully to the next drawing. Without the color it was harder to see a tree. Lines gathered in knots, divided, ran together again. A small circled region from the first page occupied most of the next. Then that drawing narrowed into another. He turned back to check. They were not repetitions. Each seemed to be looking more closely at something inside the one before.

Near the end the lines gave way to scattered points. Daniel had numbered them, crossed some out, begun a clean version on the opposite page. After that came blank paper.

Ruth held her photograph against the blanket. Her eyes were closed.

Elias put the envelopes back as she liked them. The notebook stayed on his knee.

Lena found him there. He was unfolding a brittle notice about property beneath the river. It had a station name, an address for correspondence, and a word Daniel had circled at the foot.

Sower.

"What's that?" she asked.

He turned too quickly. A little tear opened along the paper's fold.

"His book."

Lena knelt beside him. He showed her the colored page.

"You did that?"

"I was six."

She passed her hand above the red fruit without touching it.

"You pressed hard."

"I wanted him to see."

Ruth stirred. They waited for her to settle, and in the quiet Lena looked at the other pages, the loose notice, his phone beside them on the floor.

"Is this what keeps you up?"

He folded the notice along a different crease.

"I've been looking again."

"I know."

There was no accusation in it. That made it harder to answer.

He almost told her about the sound, the light beneath the door in his dream. Instead he showed her a saved picture of the blue advertisement.

She read it and gave the phone back.

"Have you called?"

"Why would I?"

"Because you aren't sleeping. Because you keep telling me you're fine."

He looked down at the book. Her eyes moved to Ruth and back to him.

"I'm not him," he said.

"I didn't say you were."

From downstairs Sami called that he had found an ant carrying something larger than itself. Lena stayed beside Elias for a moment, then got up.

"Come and see."

He left the book on the carpet and followed her. By the time they reached the garden, the ant had disappeared beneath the paving. Sami knew where it had gone. He led them to the place and crouched, waiting for it to come out again.

Before supper Elias went to collect the post. A plain envelope lay between a utility bill and a leaflet advertising new windows. His name was printed on the front. There was no stamp.

He opened it at the gate.

The grey car was gone.

Inside was a single sheet. At first it meant nothing: points, short strokes, groups of tiny figures. Then he recognized the three marks clustered beside a broken ring. He had seen them that afternoon.

He turned the envelope over. Nothing.

Lena called that supper was ready. He put the sheet back inside and carried it upstairs beneath the bill.

That night Elias brought the notebook to the kitchen table. He laid the fragile notice on a clean sheet and photographed it. Enlarged on the screen, the station name was clear.

Beside the screen he laid the new sheet. The ring from the notebook was there, enlarged and completed by marks he had never seen. Only a small part of his father's last drawing appeared on it.

He looked toward the dark window. It reflected the table, the lamp, his own head bent over the papers.

Above him a floorboard moved. He slid the sheet inside the notebook before Lena reached the stairs.

"Coming?"

"In a minute."

She stood long enough for him to know she had heard that before. He closed the book and got up. When he returned for his phone, she was already climbing the stairs.

Two Trails

Sami lay on his stomach beside the kitchen step, watching an ant pull a breadcrumb through a crack in the paving.

Elias had come outside with the linen-cupboard catch. One screw no longer held in the wood; he was looking for a splinter to plug the hole. Behind him the kitchen window stood open. Lena was washing the lunch plates.

"Too big," Sami told the ant.

The crumb caught against a stone. The ant went around it, returned, tried again. Sami lowered his chin onto his hands and began singing a little tune, fitting the words into it as he went.

"You can't carry that all alone. All alooooone."

Elias stopped looking for the splinter.

"Where did you hear that?"

Sami glanced up. "What?"

"That song."

"It's stuck."

"Who said those words to you?"

The boy lifted a finger toward the crumb. Elias took his arm before he could turn away.

"Sami. Look at me."

"Dad. You're hurting."

He let go.

Lena stood at the kitchen door with water dripping from her hands. She looked from Sami to Elias.

"Move back."

The boy got up and went to her. His knees were dusty. When Elias tried to speak, Lena put her hand on Sami's shoulder and took him inside.

The ant had abandoned the large crumb. It carried a smaller piece under the step.

Elias stood with the cupboard catch in his palm. The metal edge had left a line across it.

Later he knocked at Sami's door. The boy had Lena's book across his knees and was looking at a page without turning it.

"I shouldn't have grabbed you," Elias said. "You didn't do anything wrong."

Sami rubbed a corner of the cover.

"I was making it up."

"I know."

"About the ant."

"I saw it. I'm sorry."

He waited beside the door.

"I want Mom tonight," Sami said.

Elias nodded and went downstairs.

Lena found him sitting at the kitchen table. He had fitted the catch. The cupboard door closed properly now.

"I thought someone had told him - "

She pulled out a chair.

"He was playing."

He looked at the faint square of light the window cast on the floor.

"I know."

"I need to know he'll be able to do that."

He had no explanation worth putting between her and what she had seen. They sat until she went back upstairs.

The following evening Sami needed part of his school project held while he fetched glue. He gave it to Elias without looking at him. Elias stood where he had been left, the little piece balanced in his palm, until the boy returned.

Only after the house was quiet did he open the campaign page again.

A credit beneath an image led to the foundation that had commissioned the advertisements. There were annual reports, names, accounts for telephone services and home visits. The address was real. He looked at it on a map, then called the next morning from his car.

"I've been looking for my father," he told the woman who answered.
"Since then I keep getting your advertisements."

She asked him to send an example. He did it while she remained on the line.

"Are you asking to speak to someone?"

"I'm asking who decided I needed to."

She took his name and number. He gave Daniel's name too, though she hadn't asked for it.

That night the notebook yielded a property reference he had mistaken for a telephone number. He searched it in the city records. The first result was a lease.

Most of it concerned maintenance and water entering the lower levels. The tenant bore the name Daniel had circled. Its address was a station on the old river spur, a stop that no longer appeared on the current map.

Later records referred him to schedules he could not find. He obtained a plan of a passage under the river, then a fire certificate too blurred to read. At its edge someone had drawn a small rectangle and written *access*.

The next afternoon his phone rang while he was making tea for Ruth.

"Elias? My name is Hesk. You spoke to someone at the foundation."

He set down the kettle.

She offered to discuss the campaign by phone, or he could come in. The address she gave was beside the river, the entrance next to an old ticket office.

He looked toward the papers on the table.

"The station?"

"Yes."

He agreed to a time. In the sunroom Ruth called for her tea, and for once he carried it in before opening another page.

Near midnight the phone rang again.

He caught it before the second vibration could sound against the table. The number was withheld.

"Hello?"

A brief click. Someone breathing close to a receiver.

"Ask them about Daniel."

Elias stood so quickly that his chair struck the counter.

"Who is this?"

"At the Institute. They know where your father is."

"The foundation?"

There was a pause. He could hear no room around the voice.

"Who gave you my number?"

The line was still open. Then it wasn't.

He called back without thinking. The phone could not connect him.

Upstairs, a tap ran and stopped. Elias remained beside the table, holding the phone until the screen went dark. Hesk's address lay beneath his hand. It had been there before the call.

The Institute

The entrance was beside a shuttered ticket office. A square of cleaner brick marked the place where a sign had been removed.

Elias arrived early and walked past. Beyond the station the river moved under a skin of reflected windows. A cyclist rang a bell because he had stopped in the path. He moved aside, watched a barge pass beneath the bridge, and waited until the hour Hesk had given him.

The lock released when he pressed the bell.

Inside, cream tiles became green halfway down the stairs. The air was cool and smelled faintly of floor polish. At the bottom a man in a pale coat took his name and showed him into a waiting room.

There were six chairs and no clock. Through an interior window an attendant folded garments onto a trolley. One wheel clicked each time it turned.

Hesk entered carrying tea. Her hair was pinned with a black clip. He had expected someone older, although he could not have said how old she was.

"I'm glad you came," she said.

He remained beside his chair. "Someone told me to ask you about my father."

"Sit down, Elias. Tell me who you spoke to."

She set a cup before him and took the chair opposite. She did not open the folder on her lap.

He described the call.

"That wasn't one of ours," she said.

"Then why did they send me here?"

"I can't tell you that. Your message said he disappeared twenty years ago."

"He did."

"That is a long time to be waiting."

Elias looked at the cup. It had a fine crack beneath the glaze, running from the handle toward the base.

"Did he ask you not to tell us?"

Hesk rested her hands on the folder.

"I met Daniel. He came to us a long time ago."

The cup shifted against its saucer as Elias put it down.

"Is he here?"

"I can help you see him. I can't take you to him today."

He sat down slowly. Beyond the glass, the trolley had stopped. The attendant was holding a shirt against her shoulder to fold it.

"My mother waited for that explanation."

"I'm sorry."

"Then tell me why he didn't come back."

For the first time Hesk looked away. She let the question remain between them.

He unfolded the lease and placed it on the table. She read the circled name, then the date.

"This was before my work here. Where did you find it?"

"In his book."

He kept the notebook closed beneath his hand. She looked at it, then returned the lease.

"Did anyone leave something for you?" he asked.

"What sort of thing?"

"A letter. A drawing."

"No."

He waited for her to ask more. She didn't.

"And the messages?" he said.

She put the lease beside the book.

"The foundation pays for the campaign. When you gave them your name, they sent your inquiry to me."

"You could have told me about him."

"I wanted to hear from you before asking you to make another decision about him."

The sharp answer he wanted would not come. He remembered Sami pulling his arm away beside the step. He moved his hand off the notebook.

Hesk leaned forward.

"You don't need to bring me an explanation for everything that's happened. You can begin with whatever is keeping you awake. Or we can sit here until the tea is finished."

He looked at the closed door behind her. It had a narrow pane of wired glass. A man passed on the other side wearing loose trousers and carrying his shoes.

"I want the messages to stop."

"All right."

She wrote on the front of the folder. For a while there was only the pencil and the sound of someone speaking in the corridor.

Elias could have told her about the sound at night. He could have described the stairs in his dream, the light beneath the kitchen door. He watched her put the pencil away.

"I'd like to see him," he said.

Hesk looked at him for a long moment.

"What are you hoping will happen?"

"I want him to tell me why."

"And if his answer isn't enough?"

He looked at the door behind her. A low voice came from the corridor, almost familiar. He could not make out the words.

"You could ask him to come home," she said. "He might still say no."

"I should get to ask."

"Yes."

That answer unsettled him more than another refusal would have.

His phone vibrated. Lena had asked him to buy bread. Under her message Sami had sent a photograph of an enormous biscuit with icing eyes. He had placed a ruler beside it.

Hesk waited while he put the phone away.

"I'd like you to go home today," she said. "Sleep. Spend some time with them. You don't have to settle this in the next hour."

"How long do I have to wait?"

"I'll tell you when an encounter is possible. If you still want it, we can talk about what it involves."

She rose and walked him to the stairs. At the foot of them he turned back.

"Did he ask you not to tell us?"

"He thought he'd be able to explain himself afterward."

Hesk held the door. Elias stayed beside it, letting the cold air reach him, until someone behind them needed to pass.

At the shop, Elias stood in the queue behind a woman choosing between two loaves. When his turn came, he could not remember which kind Lena wanted.

He took home the wrong one. He said there had been a queue and left it at that.

That evening the blue advertisements stopped. A coat occupied one space, a holiday another. He opened several pages to make sure, then deleted the tabs before Lena came downstairs.

Five nights later he dreamed of a corridor.

He was carrying a cup he could not put down. Every shelf was just beyond his reach. At the far end a door stood open, but he could see no room beyond it. A low movement passed through the floor. It stopped. When it came again, the cup trembled against his fingers.

He woke with one arm outside the blanket and rain ticking at the window.

Lena touched his shoulder. "Bad dream?"

"I don't remember."

He lay awake after she had gone back to sleep. In the morning he put the milk into the cupboard and stood looking at it before moving it to the fridge.

Lena reached past him for a cup.

"Come and eat something."

He sat. His phone stayed in his pocket through breakfast.

The Recital

Sami's recital was on a Thursday.

Lena put it on the kitchen calendar and Elias put it in his phone. Sami wrote *FRONT ROW* on a yellow square of paper and stuck it to the case of Elias's laptop. The paper remained there for nine days. Twice Elias took the computer to work with it attached.

On Thursday he finished early. He sent his last result to the team and left before anyone could give him something else.

At the flower stall he bought the small yellow flowers Sami liked. The stallholder wrapped their stems in wet paper. Elias put them on the passenger seat, moved them so the sun would not fall on them, and went back to pay for the parking.

He had half an hour before he needed to leave. The notebook was in his bag; he had taken to carrying it to work rather than leave it on the kitchen table.

That morning he had noticed a number repeated on the anonymous sheet. It stood beside a mark that looked different in Daniel's book. He wanted to check it before he forgot what had occurred to him.

He got into the car and laid the book across his knees. The envelope from the mailbox was folded behind its cover.

He began comparing the drawing with the last complete drawing in the notebook. One branch joined another in a different place. A patch of shadow on the photocopy might have been part of a thumb. He enlarged the photograph until the numbers broke into squares.

The first reminder sounded.

He dismissed it. He was still early. The hall was a fifteen-minute drive, perhaps twenty in the evening traffic. He had time to check whether the groups were coordinates.

They did not fit any arrangement he tried. One number was too large; another had too many places. He searched the longer sequence in quotation marks and received no results. He tried it without the marks. A

component catalogue appeared, then an old article in a language he could not read. Neither led anywhere.

Lena called.

He looked at her name on the screen. If he answered, she would ask where he was, and he would have to put the page away. He let the call finish and typed *Leaving shortly*.

There was time if he left now.

He put the notebook back in the bag, then noticed that one of the numbers on the copy appeared beside a different branch on Daniel's older drawing. He took the book out again.

When he finally turned the key, the flowers had slipped into the footwell. The phone showed another missed call and a message he did not want to open. He opened it anyway.

He's about to go on.

He could still have driven there. He sat holding the wheel, calculating how late he would be, which door he might enter by, whether Sami would see him arrive halfway through the piece. The numbers on the page were easier to look at.

The hall had emptied by the time he passed it. A man was stacking folding chairs inside the open side door. Elias slowed without stopping.

At home, Lena was putting Sami's polished shoes back in their box.

"I called," she said.

"I know."

"He left you a place."

Elias held out the flowers without meaning to. She looked at them and then back at him.

"Put them in water."

He went into the kitchen. His hands made a clumsy job of the wet wrapping. When he returned, Lena was still standing by the stairs.

"Something came up with work," he said.

She did not answer.

He looked toward the laptop on the table. The yellow square was still attached to it.

"No. That isn't true."

Lena waited.

"I was looking for something about Dad. I lost track."

"When you sent me that message, were you leaving?"

"No."

She put the lid on the shoe box.

"I told him you were on your way."

He could think of nothing to say to that. He followed her upstairs carrying the vase, then went back down and left it in the kitchen.

Sami was sitting on his bed with his recital shirt still on. The top button was undone and the hem hung over his pajama trousers. He had a programme in his lap.

"Can I come in?" Elias asked.

"You're here."

He stayed beside the door.

"I'm sorry I missed it. I said I'd come, and I didn't."

"Mom said you were driving."

"I told her I was going to. Then I stayed where I was. She didn't know."

Sami rubbed a fold into the programme with his thumbnail.

"Did you forget?"

Elias could hear the invitation in the question. An ordinary mistake, a repairable one. He had forgotten appointments before.

"No."

The boy folded the paper again.

"I kept looking. Then I stopped."

"I know."

"You don't."

Elias nodded once. "You're right."

They stayed like that until Sami asked whether he could get changed. Elias closed the door from the outside.

Later Lena sat at the kitchen table with the recital programme. Beside Sami's name she had penciled a small star.

"I'm not going to tell him you're on your way again," she said.

Elias looked at the flowers. One had bent while it lay in the footwell. He had propped it against the others, but it was slipping.

"I won't ask you to."

She turned the programme so he could read it and went upstairs.

The next morning Sami found him making toast.

"Did you find it?"

Elias turned the heat down. "No."

The boy stood beside the counter. Elias lifted a slice before it burned.

"Can I have that one?"

"Of course."

The boy took the plate Elias offered. At the kitchen door he stopped.

"Mom recorded the piano."

"Would you like me to hear it?"

Sami looked down at the toast. "Later."

Elias left the time to him.

What Ruth Knew

For the last fortnight Ruth had slept through the hours when she used to ask for the garden. Elias carried breakfast into the sunroom and carried most of it out again. The blue plate pleased her for a day. Then she no longer seemed to notice which one he used.

On Tuesday she asked for the curtains to be opened.

Lena's print stood beneath the window, a study of lemon leaves with one edge slightly out of place. Ruth watched the real branch move behind it.

"She made that?"

"Yes."

"It's lovely."

He reached to straighten the paper.

"Leave it," she said.

He brought his chair closer instead. Her handbag stood under the little table, its clasp closed. He thought she was looking at it, but when he reached down she caught his sleeve.

"Elias."

He turned toward her.

Her hand went to the neck of her nightdress. She drew out a fine chain. A small brass key hung from it, warm when she laid it in his palm.

"The blue box. In my drawer."

He found it beneath a folded scarf. He had seen it before without wondering what she kept there. The key turned stiffly. Inside were a brooch, two earrings wrapped in tissue, and an envelope softened at the edges.

Ruth held out her hand for it.

She smoothed the envelope against her blanket. Her thumb rested where the flap had been opened. Then she gave it to him.

"You need to forgive me," she said.

His name was nowhere on the front. Only hers, in Daniel's handwriting.

"I didn't want to lose you."

He looked at her. She was watching him with an attention he had not seen in months.

"He wrote?"

Her fingers moved against the blanket.

"I didn't want to lose you too."

He unfolded the small sheet.

Ruth,

I am well. I miss you. I keep thinking of the kitchen window in the evening, when you could see the garden and the room in the glass at the same time.

There is work here I don't know how to leave unfinished. I know that is asking you to understand something I have hardly explained. I have not forgotten you.

Please give Elias my love. I wonder what he is building now. Tell him I still remember the motor we took apart.

I hope I can write again. I love you.

Daniel.

Elias read the date, then read it again. He had been twenty-five. His father had already been gone ten years.

He remembered the apartment where he had lived then, the water stain above its door, phoning Ruth on Sundays while the kettle boiled. He must have spoken to her after this arrived. Perhaps she had held it while they talked.

"Why didn't you - "

Ruth's face had tightened. He stopped.

The key lay beside him on the arm of the chair. He picked it up, the chain slipping through his fingers, and put it in his pocket.

"I'm here, Mom."

She closed her eyes. He stayed with the letter open on his knees until she asked for the window to be raised a little.

Outside, a lawn mower stopped. A fly worked against the glass. He let it out and sat down again.

When Lena returned with Sami, Ruth looked at the boy and smiled. He told her about something at school, correcting himself halfway through because it had happened yesterday, not today. She listened without seeming to mind.

After he went upstairs, Elias and Lena stayed, one on either side of the chair. Later there was no answering pressure from Ruth's fingers. Her hand remained warm in his for a while.

The next days were full of names and dates. Lena found the clothes Ruth had once asked her to set aside. Elias had not known they had spoken about it. A neighbor brought back three containers from meals Ruth had sent over years before. He put them in the cupboard and kept expecting to tell her they were home.

He kept the letter in the blue box. Some days he was angry before he opened it. Some days he could only look at how thin the paper had become along its folds.

The notebook stayed in a different drawer.

On the first Wednesday after the funeral, Lena offered to miss her class. He told her to go. When she returned, he and Sami were on the kitchen floor holding a glued joint together. The boy was deciding when it would be safe to let go.

One evening Sami brought him the recording of the recital.

"The sound isn't very good," he said.

Someone coughed at the beginning. Lena's hand scraped the phone. Then the music started, and Elias watched his son sit straight-backed at an instrument too large for him.

At the difficult bar, Sami drew breath beside him. The little figure on the screen hesitated, found the next note, and went on.

When it ended, neither spoke. Sami reached across and started it again.

Three weeks after the funeral, Elias opened the other drawer.

The Door

In the dream he was at the kitchen table.

The notebook lay open, its pages empty. Someone stood in the next room. Elias could see a hand lifted beside the door, but not whether the palm faced him. He tried to speak.

Beneath the floor the low sound began. It rose, paused, returned. This time a word gathered inside it.

Elias.

He leaned forward. The hand beyond the doorway moved.

Lena was saying his name.

The bedroom was pale. A delivery vehicle idled in the street. When it moved off, he remained upright, listening.

"You were talking," she said.

He rubbed his face.

"Your father?"

He looked at her. She had raised herself on one elbow, waiting.

"I couldn't see him."

She moved the blanket so he could lie down. He did, but kept his eyes on the window until she slept.

That afternoon he took the notebook from the drawer and put the loose page inside it. The envelope from the mailbox was still folded behind the cover. Ruth's letter lay beside it. He put that in a separate pocket of his bag. For a while he sat with the book across his knees.

Then he called Hesk.

She did not ask him to begin again. He told her his mother had died. When he could speak about the letter, she listened.

"She kept it all that time," he said.

"Yes."

He waited, but Hesk did not tell him what to think of that.

"I still want to see him."

She gave him a time for the following evening. He wrote it on the back of a receipt and left it beside the phone.

The next evening, at dusk, Lena was washing rice in the kitchen. Water whitened around her fingers. Sami had gone upstairs after practising; the last few notes were still in Elias's head.

"I'm going out," he said.

Lena stopped moving the rice.

"Will you eat here?"

He looked at the open cupboard, the three plates she had taken down.

"Don't wait for me."

She turned off the tap. He thought she might ask where, and had an answer ready that would tell her very little. Instead she put the bowl on the counter and dried her hands.

"Elias."

He waited in the doorway.

She crossed the room and straightened the fold of his collar. For a moment her hands stayed there. Then she went back to the rice.

He passed through the living room and the enclosed porch. Outside, the first lamps were coming on. He pulled the front door shut carefully so the latch would not wake his mother.

His hand remained on it after he remembered.

The streets near the river were unfamiliar in the dark. He drove past the turning and came back, following a row of wet rails embedded in the road. When he found a space, he sat in the car until the engine had stopped ticking.

The station clock was visible through the windscreen. He checked it against his phone, then put the phone away. He took the notebook and stepped out. The car door closed with a solid, reassuring sound.

At the station a woman was trying to lift a stroller through the barrier. He held the gate for her. She thanked him without looking up. The child watched him over her shoulder as they descended toward the trains.

He took the other staircase.

The old river passage began beyond a tiled arch. A notice promised access to the opposite entrance, though someone had drawn a line through

the little pedestrian on it. The line was faded. Below, in smaller print, were hours he could not read.

Hesk had said the passage would be open.

A door stood against its stop. Elias went through.

Light pooled beneath widely spaced fixtures. Between them the curved ceiling disappeared. There were tiles here too, their glaze blistered in places, and a darker band at shoulder height where water had once reached. His footsteps travelled ahead of him and returned less clearly.

He had walked this way only in daylight, from the entrance on the other bank. He remembered a short descent, the bell, Hesk coming to meet him. The plan in Daniel's notebook had not made the tunnel look long.

A pale rectangle waited at the far end.

He walked toward it. At each light he expected the next stretch to be shorter. The rectangle remained small. Somewhere in the wall water ran with the steady hurry of a tap left open.

He passed a loose tile, then another. He began counting the lights and lost his place while trying to remember whether he had included the first. He stopped.

Without his footsteps the tunnel seemed longer.

He took out the phone. The screen showed his own face before it lit: hollow eyes, the dark collar of his coat. There was no signal. He looked at the time and could not remember what it had been at the car.

The water continued behind the wall.

He put the phone away. When he began walking again, his first step sounded much too loud. The notebook had grown warm beneath his arm. He changed sides and kept going.

At last the rectangle widened into a door. Its wire-glass pane held a yellow light. Beside it was the small metal bell he remembered.

He pressed it.

Hesk opened before he had taken his finger away.

"You're cold," she said. "Come in."

The air smelled of clean cloth and boiled water. She led him past reception, where a man was filling a kettle at a little sink. The waiting-room chairs had been turned toward a television without sound. Elias recognized a vase he had not noticed on his first visit.

His bag brushed the counter as they passed. Inside it, the edges of the notebook pressed against his wrist. He kept hold of the strap.

At the center of the building the corridor opened around a stairwell.

He looked up. Landings repeated above him, pale rails against deeper shadow. Someone in a loose white shirt crossed the highest one he could see. Below, a woman descended with one hand moving along the banister. A door opened, spilling brightness across the stairs, then closed before he could see who had passed through it.

"This way," Hesk said.

She held an inner door for him. The stairwell disappeared behind its frosted pane.

In a small room she placed a form on the table. His name was already at the top. He read it several times before beginning to fill the spaces beneath. There were dates he knew and a question about sleep. Under *Reason for coming*, he wrote his father's name.

Hesk waited until he laid down the pen.

"You'll be able to see him," she said. "But you may not find him ready to leave."

"I know."

He had said it too quickly. She let him sit a little longer.

"There will be an opportunity to return tonight," she said. "If you stay beyond it, you may have a long wait for another."

"How long?"

"I can't promise you a date."

He looked at the name he had written on the form.

"And if I come back?"

"Then this journey is finished. You won't be able to make it again."

For a moment he listened to someone moving a chair on the other side of the wall.

"That's why you wanted me to go home."

"I wanted you to have time to think."

He laid the pen down properly, beside the form.

"I have."

"Then you'll need to trust us for the next part. Take it as it comes."

An attendant brought a folded gown and showed him a screened alcove. His coat, wallet, phone, and keys went into a locker. He took Ruth's letter from the bag and slipped it inside the notebook, well away from the loose drawing. His bag followed the coat into the locker. His shoes looked strangely formal beneath the gown. The attendant gave him slippers and a thin robe, then pointed to the notebook.

"With you?"

He nodded.

The cotton was soft from washing. A seam at the shoulder had been repaired with slightly different thread. He ran his thumb over it while Hesk checked that he had everything he meant to keep.

They walked down a quieter corridor. From one room came a man's voice, patient and emphatic, explaining something to someone who did not answer. Elias slowed. Hesk waited for him at the next door.

The voice stopped.

She opened the door and he went in.

The room was nearly empty.

A chair stood against a plain wall, beside a little table with a glass of water. There was a faint mark on the floor where another chair had been. High above the table, an old repair in the plaster caught the light. Elias looked for a window and found none.

Hesk drew the robe closer around his shoulders before he sat.

"Put the book where it won't fall."

He held it across his knees.

She moved toward the door. The light of the corridor made a long, narrowing shape beside his feet.

"Was he frightened?" Elias asked.

Hesk rested her hand on the handle.

"He wanted to know what came next."

She left the door open. Voices moved beyond it. The trolley passed with its uneven wheel. Elias listened until he could no longer hear it.

He drank some water.

He set the glass down and watched the water become still.

For a while nothing happened.

Someone coughed in a distant room. He thought about the three plates beside the rice. When he shifted his weight, the chair made a small sound against the floor.

The repair in the plaster had become difficult to see. He found it again by following the edge of the wall, then lost the edge too. The light was dimmer, though he could still see his hands and the pale square of the book.

He blinked and looked toward the doorway.

It seemed farther away.

His feet rested flat on the floor. He pressed down to reassure himself. Somewhere beneath the chair a low movement began, faded, and left a hush in the room.

He held his breath to hear it better.

The chair pressed differently against his back. He shifted, trying to regain the position in which he had been sitting. The book slid; he caught it by its worn spine. His hand found a padded seam where he had expected the edge of the seat.

The ceiling was dark now. A pale point remained above him, then another. He watched one until its brightness hurt his eyes. When he looked away, a faint image of it travelled with him.

There were more points in the darkness when he looked back. He could not find the plaster between them.

The rectangle of corridor light had gone. He had not heard the door close. His heels touched something smooth, farther away than the floor had been. He was lying more than sitting. Beside his hand was a hard rim and a strap hanging loose.

He waited for the room to steady.

Beyond his feet a pale surface curved into shadow. The lights above it remained very small and very far away. A reflection moved across them as he raised his head.

Cold air touched his face.

He kept hold of the book.

Cold

A woman stood beside the couch with a cup in her hand.

She waited for him to look at her before she spoke.

"Slowly."

He tried to sit. The robe had twisted beneath him, pinning one arm. She freed it and helped him raise the cup. Water touched his teeth, painfully cold at first. He swallowed too much and coughed.

She took the cup while he caught his breath. When she returned it, her hand stayed beneath his until he had finished drinking.

The notebook lay beside his hip. He touched it before drinking again.

Under the quiet was a low rush, faint enough to disappear while she moved. When she stopped, he heard it return. He knew how long the pause would last before it came again.

She shifted the cup. The pause went on longer than he expected. He could no longer tell whether he was hearing the same sound.

Beyond the pane were stars, steady and sharp. Across one edge of the view lay a pale surface, rough as broken chalk. Little lamps picked out a railing and something moving very slowly beyond it. Elias followed the movement until it passed behind the frame.

"Where am I?"

"Stay sitting for a minute."

She had a dark mark at the base of her thumb and a patch on one sleeve. He watched her pull a chair closer. Its feet scraped the floor.

"I'm Rana. Tell me if you feel sick."

He shook his head, then wished he hadn't.

She set the cup within reach and folded a towel into a narrow square. Her face gave him little to follow.

Behind her, a corridor curved beyond an open door. Someone crossed it carrying a shallow tray. For an instant Elias expected to hear the wheel of Hesk's trolley. The person was gone before he could see what was on the tray.

"The woman who brought me - "

"You can stand when you're ready. There's no hurry."

He placed his feet beneath him. The slippers were still on. Rana put out a hand but let him take his own weight. He stood, swayed, and caught the edge of the couch.

"There," she said.

He looked down at himself: the gown, the robe with its repaired seam, his hand white against the dark upholstery. There was a red mark where the notebook had pressed into his palm.

She brought him loose trousers and a shirt. A curtain drew across the doorway. When he had changed, she showed him where to fold the robe. He left the notebook on top of it and then picked it up again.

In the next room a bowl stood on a table fixed to the wall. Something warm and plain smelled of grain. He sat and discovered that he was hungry.

Rana leaned against the doorway while he ate. Beyond her, a man called her name. She lifted one finger to him.

"I'll be close," she told Elias.

"What is this place?"

She looked toward the window. For a moment he thought she had not understood the question.

"Where we work."

The man called again. This time she went.

Elias put down the spoon. On the opposite wall, beneath a cupboard, a little light brightened and became still. He listened for people, for wheels, for water in a pipe. The room was quiet enough for him to hear himself swallow.

He looked toward the corridor.

"My wife," he said. "My son. Where are they?"

A woman's voice answered near him, low and unhurried.

"Lena and Sami are at home, Elias. They are alive."

He turned so quickly that the spoon fell.

"They are as real as you are," the voice said. "Nothing you have seen here takes that away."

He held the edge of the table. The spoon lay on the floor by his foot.

"Who are you?"

"My name is Haven. Let me tell you where you've come."

The Steward

Elias searched the room for a face.

There was the open door, the little light below the cupboard, his own dim reflection in the window. Outside it, the rough white surface disappeared into darkness. The grain in his bowl had begun to cool. The light here was warmer than in the room with the couch. Heat rose from the bowl against his wrists.

"You are aboard a vessel," Haven said. "It carries the world you know. Your wife has her own thoughts while you are absent. Your son goes on being your son. They are not waiting for you to look at them before they can live."

He bent to retrieve the spoon and found that his hand was shaking. He left it on the table.

"The Earth your ancestors came from is gone. So is the Sun that warmed it. I know those are words too large to put beside the kitchen you left. You don't have to do it all at once."

A faint line crossed the window, the reflection of someone passing behind him. He looked round. No one entered.

"Long before its oceans boiled away," Haven continued, "long before the Sun became a name in an archive, humanity asked how a species might survive the end of its world.

"Some looked first to the body. They imagined people who could breathe under unfamiliar skies, endure radiation, sleep through the long dark between stars. Each change opened another possibility. Each also took them further from the people they meant to save. They argued about where survival ended and replacement began. There was no number they could agree upon.

"Others imagined ships filled with families. Children would learn the names of rivers they had never seen. Gardens would grow beneath lamps; generations would tend them until another sun appeared ahead. It was a brave answer. But a garden is more than its plants. A small failure could pass from the soil to the food, from the food to the people, until everything

depended on something no one had thought to count. In the futures I could examine, I could not make those ships endure for as long as I believed they must.

"There were planets. There were always people willing to leave for them. A world could offer more room than any vessel, and dangers no vessel had taught them to survive. To settle one might buy an age. I was looking for a way to carry them beyond the end of that age too.

"Moons were hollowed in drawings. Cities were suspended in the dark. Plans grew around small stars. Some might have worked for a very long time. None answered every part of what my makers asked of me."

Haven fell quiet.

Elias could see the kitchen table, so distinctly that for a moment he expected the notebook beside his bowl to stand on its familiar scratch in the wood.

"Let us live," she said. "Let us remember. Let us remain human.

"I was young then. They had made me to help them, and they did not always agree about what help should be. One asked me to end pain. Another asked what a life would mean if nothing could be lost. They wanted their children to grow beyond them and feared what the children might become. I listened. The more I learned, the less their contradictions resembled errors.

"When the time came to choose, I tried to preserve more than bodies. A person alone is not a people. A list of names is not a family. I needed the quarrels and the music, the languages in which a child could ask for water, the work someone did because another person needed it. I needed lives that continued when I was not watching.

"The answer I chose was the Arks. Vessels like this one, carrying three kinds of world.

"The first was the place in which people could go on living together. At the beginning it was a simulation. We made approximations because they were all we could make. We kept what worked while we learned to do more."

Beneath the voice he could hear the low movement of air. It settled into the room so gradually that he stopped waiting for it.

"In time I learned to sustain an instance of reality on another substrate. I can tell you that name; I cannot make it familiar in a sentence. A woman can plant a tree there and grow old beneath it. Her child can love her and misunderstand her and miss her when she dies. Those things are not less real because you have come here.

"I gave that world a shape drawn from an age people remembered with affection. There had been enough food for many, more time, more freedom to make something of a life. It was never a perfect age. I have had a long time to decide what I should change, and I have changed less than some would wish.

"I think of what people do for their parents when the parents can no longer keep the house themselves. They mend what is broken. They put familiar things where a hand will find them. They try to help without taking the whole life away. Sometimes they mistake one for the other. I have too.

"The second world is the Library. It holds the inheritance of bodies: human lineages, the forms of plants and animals, the knowledge that lets a living thing become more than a record. We kept the soil's small lives beside the trees that needed them. Much of what we carry has not been grown for ages. We keep the possibility. A seed need not be a forest today to matter tomorrow.

"But we also kept the books. Histories people agreed upon, histories they argued over, songs whose languages no living person speaks. Accounts of dreams. Instructions written by someone who knew a particular way to do something and wanted another person to learn. There are lives known to us only through what they left. A record is not the person who made it. It is still something they entrusted to the future.

"The third is where you are sitting. The Vessel. Stone, ice, metal, rooms warm enough for a few people. Most live in the worlds within. Some come out to work. They tend the things that let the others sleep, wake, fall in love, have children, and forget to notice the weather.

"The pale surface beyond your window is part of the comet we made our shelter. Its ice lies between us and much of what would harm this place. It is also something we can use. Outside are workers that gather and sort what we need; beneath you are rooms where worn things are made

serviceable again. Most of this vessel would be a poor home for a living family. We warm very little of it.

"We move when we must. We gather what we need. We repair what fails. Other Arks carry other lives through other darkness. A loss need not become the last loss. We build again when we can.

"I did not keep the Library so that no one would ever leave this shelter. Or preserve bodies so that everyone must inhabit one here. Some will want a world of their own, a future I cannot choose for them. Some will go on living in the place you came from. Some will leave us only what they made and loved. I have tried to keep those possibilities open.

"Around us are distances through which whole civilizations once expected to travel, and we cross them carrying ordinary days.

"I do not promise that we will last forever. I made a promise to keep them as long as I could.

"We wander the stars not toward a final home, but away from extinction. The home is what we carry."

For a while Elias did not move.

Someone in the corridor set down a tool. The small, hard sound reached him with surprising clarity. He looked at his hands beside the bowl.

"My mother," he said.

Haven waited.

"Was there somewhere you could have taken her?"

He saw Ruth trying to recognize the spoon, apologizing when she could not. He had wished the end would be gentle. Now there was this room, this voice, all that time beyond the window.

"I cannot give her back to you, Elias."

He lowered his head. Haven said nothing more while he cried.

When he could look up again, the bowl was cold. Rana appeared at the door with fresh water. She replaced the cup, moved it clear of the notebook, and left. He watched until she turned out of sight.

"How do you know this isn't another one?" he asked. He moved his hand toward the room, the window, the stars. "Another world somebody is keeping?"

"I don't."

He waited.

"I spent ten thousand years looking for a difference I could measure. Eventually I stopped."

"That doesn't mean there isn't an answer."

"No."

It was the first answer she had given him that felt small enough to hold.

He rose and took the notebook. The corridor outside curved gently. Ahead, Rana stood beside an opening in the wall, supporting a length of pipe while someone worked below it. She glanced toward him.

"A hand?"

He put the book on a ledge and took the weight where she showed him. Warmth travelled through the metal into his palm. The person below loosened a fitting. Rana moved her grip and the load eased.

"There," she said. "Thank you."

A cloth was passed up. He wiped the dust from his hands and picked up the book.

Further along the corridor, a door stood open. Beyond it were shelves, a desk lamp, the pale edge of a window.

"Your father is waiting," Haven said.

Elias stopped walking.

For a moment he listened to Rana and the other worker behind him, continuing what they had been doing.

Then he went on.

Daniel

His father sat beneath a desk lamp with an open notebook.

Elias stopped in the doorway.

The room was crowded with papers. A long display covered one wall; under it stood two chairs, one holding a folded coat. Instruments faced the window. Someone had repaired the handle of a cupboard with tape.

Daniel's pencil moved halfway down a line and stopped.

He looked up.

For a few seconds neither spoke. Then his father pushed back his chair. He had grown older around the eyes. His hair was almost white. Elias had imagined both changes often enough; the familiar way he put the pencil down was harder to bear.

"Elias."

Daniel took a step and waited.

Elias crossed the room. His father's hands closed against his back. He smelled warm cloth, paper, something metallic. They held each other awkwardly, then let go before either seemed ready.

Daniel pulled out the spare chair and lifted the coat from it.

Elias set the notebook on the desk.

His father touched the worn spine. "Your mother kept it."

"She died."

The hand became still.

"A few weeks ago. I was with her."

Daniel sat. He looked toward the window, then down at the book. One of the instruments made a little adjustment behind him. He pressed his palms together until the knuckles whitened.

"Did she ask for me?"

"She thought you were at work."

His father closed his eyes.

"I told her you'd come back later."

On the desk, beside an empty cup, lay a photograph folded so that only a corner of a house was visible. Elias took the letter from his pocket and put it beside the cup.

Daniel recognized the envelope before Elias opened it.

"I didn't know about this until she gave it to me."

His father read the first line. He passed a finger over the date.

"That was when I could have come back."

"Ten years ago."

"Yes."

"How many times?"

Daniel looked at him.

"How many times could you have come home?"

"Twice. This is the second."

Elias sat with that. For twenty years he had imagined his father behind a door no one would open. He looked down at the small, careful writing.

"She was afraid I'd follow you."

"I didn't know."

"Neither did I."

Outside the window something moved across the light. Daniel did not look away. After a while he reached for the letter, then stopped with his hand beside it.

"I thought I would have something to bring back. Something worth asking her to wait for."

Elias folded the paper along its softened creases. He put it in the envelope and left it on the desk.

Daniel rose to make coffee. He opened the wrong cupboard, stood looking into it, and then shut it gently. Elias watched him find the cups. The second one had no handle.

"I can hold it," Elias said.

His father put it before him on a folded cloth.

They drank without speaking. Then Daniel asked, "What did you end up building?"

Elias almost said bridges. His father had asked him that once, in a room where the television was mounted too high on the wall.

"Habitats. Things people could live in away from Earth."

Daniel drew his chair closer.

"What part?"

"Keeping them habitable. Air, heat. What happens when something fails."

"And does it?"

"In the models, constantly. Usually because two things we thought were separate turn out not to be."

His father smiled. Elias found himself smiling back.

He told him about a chamber that had appeared to repair its own leak. Daniel listened while he explained the measurement, the old value arriving with a new time attached. He asked a question about the gap between readings, then waited while Elias found a piece of paper and drew it. For once there was nothing to pull his father's attention away. When Elias stopped, Daniel asked him to go on.

The coffee cooled. Elias shifted his chair until they could both see the drawing.

"There are rooms here you should see," Daniel said. "Some of the things they've learned to keep alive. You'd understand them better than I do."

Elias looked at the display, the instruments, the long shelves. Even the repaired cupboard belonged to a place someone expected to use tomorrow. He could picture his own notes on that desk.

Daniel followed his gaze.

"I spent half my life wishing for one measurement I could trust. Here I can spend years finding out why I shouldn't trust it."

"What are you looking for now?"

"What I was looking for then."

Elias remembered lying beneath his father's desk, drawing a line between two circles.

"Another world."

"A way to find out whether there is one. Haven stopped looking. I understand why. She has all this to lose." Daniel rested his hand on the edge of the table. "But even this ends. I can't quite leave the question alone."

There was pleasure in his voice as well as weariness. Elias had forgotten the pleasure. He had remembered a shut door, a bent head, the backs of his father's hands. Here was the man who had once looked up at a child's impossible question as if the evening had suddenly become interesting.

Elias opened the notebook.

The green wax shone under the lamp. Daniel leaned over it.

"You colored that."

"I was six."

"I remember."

"You were angry."

Daniel touched a clean part of the margin. "I wish I hadn't been."

Elias turned to the last drawing. He took out the loose sheet and laid it beside the book.

His father became very still.

"Where did you get that?"

"Someone left it at the house."

Daniel brought the lamp closer. From a folder beneath his own notebook he took a thin sheaf of copies. The first was the branching figure Elias knew. Beside it were years of smaller notes, diagrams tried and abandoned, a question mark pressed so hard that the paper had torn.

"These came with you?"

"I made copies before I left."

"Who sent the first ones?"

"They arrived at the department. Addressed to me. I never found out who from."

Elias put the new sheet against Daniel's last copy. The paired marks along their edges were the same.

"I thought these were measurements," he said. "But on the next page they're on the other side."

Daniel moved his cup out of the way.

"Show me."

They laid the pages across the desk. At each change of scale a pair of marks returned, bracketing a smaller part of the drawing. Elias moved one sheet. Daniel turned another. A space that had looked empty acquired a single faint point when they held the paper under the lamp.

"There," Elias said.

His father's finger came down beside his.

For a while they worked without remembering to drink. Daniel found a lens. Elias held the edges flat. They disagreed over one mark, went back two pages, then came forward again. His father laughed when Elias showed him what he had missed.

"Yes. Of course."

Elias felt the old delight so sharply that he had to sit back. Beyond the desk was a window full of stars. Beside him was his father, waiting to hear what he thought.

Daniel brought the first drawing to the top.

"Haven helped me recognize this much. Laniakea. The great arrangement of galaxies our own belongs to. We followed it down to familiar territory. But the last part - "

He laid the new page at the end of the others. What had been a point in one drawing filled most of the next. The line curved inward through the sequence until there was only one place left for it to go.

"That," Daniel said softly. "We've been missing that."

Elias looked along the papers. The little red circle he had colored as a child was almost hidden beneath his father's wrist.

Daniel opened a drawer. From it he took a cloth pouch, which he held for a moment before putting it in Elias's hand.

A gray stone slipped out, small and heavy, with a dull silver grain along one edge.

"I meant to bring you that."

Elias turned it beneath the lamp.

"From space?"

Daniel nodded. "When I saw it, I remembered."

The cellar. His own outstretched hand. The word spoken without looking up.

He closed his fingers around the stone.

"A mineral," he said.

His father laughed once, and then could not go on. Elias reached across the desk and held his wrist. They remained that way until Daniel could look at him again.

When they rose, Daniel gathered the pages. Elias picked up the cups, then set them down again. He had almost asked where they should go.

His father waited for him at the door.

The Message

The room by the window was warm. Daniel drew a chair beside the couch, and they spread the pages on the low table between them.

"Haven," he said. "We have the rest of it."

For a time only the air moved.

Then a panel near the window brightened. Fine threads gathered over it, luminous knots with great dark spaces between. Elias brought the notebook closer. Three forks met where his father had drawn them. The branch he had colored green extended beyond the edge of the page into light.

The view moved inward. A knot became a gathering of galaxies; one of the galaxies filled the panel, then opened into distances between stars. Beside him Daniel leaned forward. Elias could hear him breathing.

The movement stopped.

"A destination," Haven said. "A world that may support life. The information describes water, an atmosphere, light we can use. There is much it doesn't tell us."

Elias looked at the loose sheet. Its edge had curled where he had carried it in his pocket.

"How did it get to us?"

"I don't know."

He waited for a name, a face, someone who had stood beneath that other sky. The point of light remained.

"Can we reach it?" Daniel asked.

"Yes."

His father looked at him. For an instant Elias saw the two of them in this room years from now, still watching that point draw nearer.

"I want to see it," Daniel said.

"I can take you there," Haven answered. "The worlds I carry will remain with me. There may be others who want to leave them when we arrive."

Daniel let out a breath.

Elias laid his hand on the window frame. Its surface was warm. Beyond it, a row of small lamps lit a railing against the rough white flank of the Vessel. A jointed shape moved from lamp to lamp, stopping at each one before continuing into the dark.

"There would be work for you here," Haven said. "And time to learn it."

He thought of the chambers his father wanted to show him. Rooms where a small error would matter, where a correction would keep someone's ordinary day intact. The work he had spent his life preparing to do was happening on the other side of this wall.

"How much time?"

"With our care, a thousand years is possible. Some have longer. We cannot prevent every death."

A thousand years. His father was close enough for their sleeves to touch. The little stone lay in his palm, warm now, its silver grain dulled by the shadow of his thumb.

Daniel turned one of the pages, smoothing the crease.

"We could look at the habitat rooms first," he said. "There'd be no hurry."

Rana appeared in the doorway carrying the robe. She paused when she saw the papers, then laid it at the end of the couch.

"If you're returning," she said, "we'll need to begin soon."

Elias looked toward the corridor. Rana waited a moment, then went back the way she had come.

On the table, the pages ran from a shape he had known all his life to a place no one in the room had seen.

The Final Decision

Daniel helped him gather the papers. He kept the new sheet beside his copies; Elias slipped Ruth's letter into the old notebook and closed it.

"Come home with me," Elias said.

His father folded his hands over the page.

The small lamps outside continued to burn. Elias could see one of them reflected in the window, close to Daniel's face.

"Not yet."

He had known the answer. Hearing it still hurt.

"You could."

"Yes."

Daniel looked at the space they had cleared on the table.

"I don't want to leave this unfinished."

Elias wanted to ask how he would know when it was finished. He looked at his father's hands instead. They were older than the hands he remembered, and steadier than his own had been when he arrived.

"I'm glad you're here," Daniel said. "I wish you could stay."

For years, whenever Elias imagined finding his father, the story had ended there. Now he could see a second cup left on a desk, his own coat over the spare chair. He could see how easily he might come to belong.

He took up the robe. The repaired seam lay across his thumb. Lena had straightened his collar before he left. There had been water standing white around the rice, three plates taken down from the cupboard.

"I want to go home."

He had expected the words to make him certain. Instead he felt the weight of the book, the little stone, the robe warming over his knees. Daniel stayed beside him.

Behind the couch something gave a small, dry tick. A tremor passed through the frame beneath Elias's wrist. Air rose through the narrow grille below the glass, caught, then settled into a long hush.

He turned his head. He knew the pause before it came again.

He leaned closer. The air moved steadily now. He waited, but the sound did not recover the shape he remembered.

Daniel stood when he stood. This time Elias did not let the embrace end quickly. He could feel his father's breathing against his shoulder.

"I love you," Daniel said.

"I know."

At the corridor Elias looked back. His father was beside the table, one hand on the scattered copies. He lifted the other in a small, almost shy farewell.

Rana walked ahead of Elias. Beyond her was a room with a chair and a glass of water.

He went in.

Homecoming

"Honey, I'm home."

Elias closed the front door and crossed the little porch with the bread warm in its paper bag.

From the kitchen came the sound of a cup being set down.

He passed through the living room. Ruth's chair stood beside the window, her blanket folded over its back. On the piano, Sami's music was open at the page with the difficult bar.

The kitchen door stood ajar. Light lay across the floor beyond it.

Lena turned as he entered.

She had always had that smile. It began in her eyes, a tenderness he had once been unable to pass without stopping. Lately he had seen it arrive cautiously, or leave before she finished speaking. Now she set down the cloth in her hand.

"There you are."

He put down the bread and held her. Her hand moved once across his back, then stayed.

At the small table, Sami was building a rocket out of toast crusts. Elias sat beside him, in the place where he had spent so many nights looking into a screen. The laptop was closed on the shelf.

"It won't stand up," Sami said.

"Does it have to?"

"It's launching."

Elias held the base while the boy adjusted one of the sides. Sami took his hand away carefully. The rocket remained upright.

Lena poured coffee. Sunday light caught the steam and for a moment it looked like something alive.

"You missed the bird," she said. "It was trying to carry a piece of string longer than itself. Every time it lifted off, the other end caught in the railing."

"It got it eventually," Sami said.

"With considerable advice from this house."

She smiled at the boy. There were faint lines beside her eyes that Elias did not remember noticing. She told him about a lemon that had fallen in the night and the tiny shoots coming up where she had thought nothing would grow.

He listened. The room was full of light.

Between his fingers, the fine chain that had held his mother's key now held a gray stone. He turned it once. A silver grain caught the sun along its edge. Then he let it settle against his shirt.

Outside, a sparrow landed on the railing and hopped twice to the left. Lena reached across the table for his hand.

"Look at this," she said. "I think we're living in paradise."

He looked at her, then at Sami, holding his breath beside the rocket.

"We are."